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NCE Predicted Examination Paper — 2026

2026

ENGLISH

GRADE 9 • PAPER 3 OF 4

Time Allowed: **2 hours 15 minutes**

Total Marks: **100**

Candidate Name: _____

School: _____

INSTRUCTIONS TO CANDIDATES

1. Read all instructions carefully before you begin.
2. Answer **ALL** questions in Sections A, B and D.
3. In Section C (Writing), answer **ONE** task only.
4. Write your answers in the spaces provided.
5. The marks available for each question are shown in a box [].
6. Use blue or black ink. Pencil may be used for diagrams only.
7. Dictionaries are **not** permitted.

Section	Topic	Available	Obtained
A	Reading Comprehension	30	
B	Language Use	25	
C	Writing	30	
D	Vocabulary & Word Study	15	
TOTAL		100	

SECTION A — READING COMPREHENSION [30 marks]

Read the passage carefully, then answer **ALL** the questions that follow.

Belonging Everywhere and Nowhere: The Question of Cultural Identity

In an age of globalisation, mass migration, and instant digital communication, the question of cultural identity has become more complex and more urgent than ever before. For millions of young people around the world — particularly those who grow up between two or more cultures — the question "Where are you really from?" is not simply a matter of geography. It touches the deepest layers of who they believe themselves to be.

Culture is not inherited in the way that eye colour or height might be. It is absorbed — through language, food, music, religious practice, storytelling, and the countless small rituals of daily life. For children who straddle two worlds, this absorption is often a process of negotiation: which elements of each culture to embrace, which to set aside, and how to reconcile values that sometimes appear to contradict one another.

Mauritius offers a compelling case study. Home to people of African, Indian, Chinese, and European descent, the island's population has spent centuries weaving together a rich cultural tapestry. Mauritian Creole — a language born from the collision of French, African languages, and others — is itself a testament to this blending. Yet even in such a diverse society, questions of identity are not always straightforward. Young Mauritians may feel simultaneously proud of their multicultural heritage and uncertain about which community they truly belong to.

Psychologists note that a strong and secure sense of cultural identity is linked to better mental health outcomes, higher self-esteem, and greater resilience in the face of adversity. Conversely, those who feel caught between cultures — neither fully accepted by one group nor the other — can experience what

researchers call "cultural dissonance": a persistent feeling of not quite fitting in anywhere.

There is, however, a growing movement among young people to reframe this experience not as a source of confusion, but as a source of strength. To be fluent in multiple cultures is to possess a rare kind of empathy — the ability to see the world through more than one lens, to move between communities with understanding and grace. In a world that desperately needs bridges between peoples, this is no small gift.

1. According to the passage, what does the question "Where are you really from?" touch upon for those growing up between two cultures? [1]

2. According to paragraph 2, how is culture transmitted? Identify **TWO** ways mentioned by the writer. [2]

(a)

(b)

3. What does the writer mean by the phrase "*a process of negotiation*" (paragraph 2) for children who grow up between two cultures? [2]

4. How does the writer use Mauritius as an example in paragraph 3? Explain what point the example is meant to illustrate. [2]

5. Find a word in **paragraph 1** that means *"the process of countries and people becoming more closely connected worldwide."*

[1]

6. Find a word in **paragraph 4** that means *"a sense of conflict or contradiction between different ideas or values."*

[1]

7. According to paragraph 4, what are the consequences of having a **strong** cultural identity, and what are the consequences of feeling **caught between** cultures?

[3]

8. How does the writer's tone and attitude shift between paragraphs 4 and 5? Use evidence from both paragraphs to support your answer.

[4]

9. Explain what the writer means by describing multicultural young people as potentially possessing "a rare kind of empathy." Do you find this argument convincing? Give reasons.

[4]

10. *"In a diverse society such as Mauritius, being raised between multiple cultures is an advantage, not a burden."*

[10]

Do you agree? Use **evidence from the passage** and your **own experience or ideas** to develop your answer. Write approximately 150–200 words.

SECTION B — LANGUAGE USE [25 marks]

Answer **ALL** questions in this section.

Part 1 — Active and Passive Voice [5 marks]

Rewrite each sentence by changing from **active to passive** or **passive to active** as instructed. Do **not** change the tense.

11. *The community celebrates its cultural heritage every year with a vibrant festival.* [Change to **passive**] [1]

12. *Several traditional languages are being taught to young children by local elders.* [Change to **active**] [1]

13. *Researchers have documented the cultural practices of more than forty communities.* [Change to **passive**] [1]

14. *The new cultural centre will be opened by the President next month.* [Change to **active**] [1]

15. *Globalisation is slowly eroding many minority languages and traditions.* [Change to **passive**] [1]

Part 2 — Reported Speech [5 marks]

Change each sentence into **reported speech**. Begin with the words given.

16. *"My grandmother taught me everything I know about our traditions," said the student.* [1]
The student said _____
17. *"Cultural identity shapes how we see ourselves and others," the professor explained.* [1]
The professor explained _____
18. *"Do you feel that your culture is properly represented in school?" the researcher asked the pupils.* [1]
The researcher asked the pupils _____
19. *"We will introduce new guidelines to promote cultural inclusion in schools," the minister promised.* [1]
The minister promised _____
20. *"You should learn to speak at least one of your heritage languages," the elder advised the young people.* [1]
The elder advised the young people _____

Part 3 — Conditionals [5 marks]

Complete each sentence using the correct form of the verb in brackets.

21. If schools _____ (teach) more about different cultures, students would develop greater respect for one another. (2nd conditional) [1]
22. If the government had invested more in cultural education, many traditions _____ (not / disappear). (3rd conditional) [1]
23. Unless communities _____ (preserve) their languages actively, they will be lost within a generation. [1]
24. If I _____ (grow up) in another country, I might not appreciate my own heritage as much. (2nd conditional) [1]
25. She would have spoken the language fluently had she _____ (practise) it with her grandparents as a child. (3rd conditional) [1]

Part 4 — Connectives [5 marks]

Choose the most appropriate connective from the box to complete each sentence. Each word is used **once only**.

26. Many parents work hard _____ pass their cultural traditions on to their children. [1]
27. Some young people feel proud of their dual identity; _____, others find it a source of confusion and anxiety. [1]
28. _____ many young people were born in Mauritius, they may feel a deep connection to the culture of their grandparents' homeland. [1]
29. The Creole language developed over centuries of contact between different groups; _____, it became a symbol of Mauritian unity. [1]
30. Indian communities in Mauritius have maintained many of their festivals and traditions. _____, Chinese Mauritian families have preserved their New Year celebrations and language schools. [1]

Part 5 — Tenses [5 marks]

Fill in each blank with the correct form of the verb in brackets.

31. By the time she graduated, she _____ (learn) to speak three languages fluently. [1]
32. The cultural festival _____ (hold) every year since the community was first established here in the 1950s. [1]
33. At the moment, academics _____ (debate) whether globalisation strengthens or weakens local cultures. [1]
34. He _____ (write) his thesis on Mauritian Creole for two years when he finally submitted it last spring. [1]
35. The organisation _____ (announce) the winners of the cultural heritage award at next month's ceremony. [1]

SECTION C — WRITING [30 marks]

Choose **ONE** task only. Write between **250 and 350 words**. Plan your answer before you write.

TASK A — Formal Letter

Write a **formal letter** to the Director of the National Heritage Fund, arguing that more resources should be invested in preserving the minority languages and traditions of Mauritius. Include specific examples of what is at risk, the consequences of inaction, and concrete proposals for how the funding should be used.

TASK B — Discursive Essay

Write a **discursive essay** with the title: *"Globalisation is destroying cultural diversity."* Present both sides of the argument, using relevant examples, before reaching a justified conclusion that reflects your own view.

TASK C — Creative Writing

Write a **short story** about a young person who travels to their grandparents' home country for the first time and discovers something unexpected about their own identity. Focus on vivid descriptive detail and the emotions of your central character.

Task chosen (circle): **A** **B** **C**



SECTION D — VOCABULARY AND WORD STUDY [15 marks]

Part 1 — Idioms in Context [5 marks]

For each sentence, explain the meaning of the underlined idiom **as used in context**. Write your answer in the space provided.

36. "Growing up between two cultures, Leila always felt caught between two stools — not quite belonging to either world." [1]

Meaning:

37. "When the new student joined the school, the teacher made sure she felt at home from her very first day." [1]

Meaning:

38. "My grandfather says that those who forget their roots will eventually lose their way." [1]

Meaning:

39. "Despite moving to a completely different country, she kept her culture alive by cooking traditional meals every Sunday." [1]

Meaning:

40. "The young artist's work speaks volumes about the experience of growing up between cultures." [1]

Meaning:

Part 2 — Word Forms [5 marks]

Complete the table by writing the missing word form in each **shaded cell**. One mark per correct answer.

Verb	Noun	Adjective
diversify		diverse
	identity	identical
integrate	integration	
	tradition	traditional
represent		representative

[5 marks: 1 mark per shaded cell]

Part 3 — Phrasal Verbs [5 marks]

Match the phrasal verb in bold with its meaning from the box. Write the correct letter in the space provided.

A. to discover unexpectedly **B.** to maintain or continue **C.** to admire greatly **D.** to pass to the next generation
E. to feel accepted or included

41. "She **came across** an old photograph of her great-grandmother while sorting through family documents." Answer: _____ [1]
42. "The community worked hard to **hand down** its oral storytelling traditions to the next generation." Answer: _____ [1]
43. "At first she struggled, but after joining the cultural club she finally began to **fit in**." Answer: _____ [1]
44. "He **looks up to** his grandfather, who preserved their native language despite decades of pressure to assimilate." Answer: _____ [1]
45. "The village elders urged the youth to **keep up** the traditional dance practices that had been passed down for centuries." Answer: _____ [1]

MARK SCHEME — Paper 3 (Culture / Identity)

For teacher / examiner use. Accept any answer that is clearly correct in meaning. Where own words are required, do not award marks for direct quotation unless stated. Apply the writing grid for Q10 and Section C.

Q	Acceptable Answer(s)	Mark
1	It touches the deepest layers of who they believe themselves to be / their sense of self / identity. (Accept any paraphrase; 1 mark.)	1
2	Any two from: language; food; music; religious practice; storytelling; daily rituals / small rituals of daily life. (1 mark each.)	2
3	The writer means that children who grow up between two cultures must decide which elements of each culture to accept or keep, which to reject, and how to make sense of values that seem to clash with one another. (1 mark for the idea of choosing/deciding; 1 mark for the idea of reconciling conflicting values.)	2
4	The writer uses Mauritius to show that even in a highly diverse / multicultural society, identity can still be complex and uncertain. The example of Mauritian Creole language illustrates how cultures blend together, yet even within this blended society, young people can feel unsure where they truly belong. (1 mark for the point about diversity being complex; 1 mark for the linguistic example or sense of uncertainty.)	2
5	globalisation	1
6	dissonance (accept: "cultural dissonance")	1
7	Strong identity: better mental health outcomes, higher self-esteem, and greater resilience in adversity. Caught between cultures: "cultural dissonance" — a persistent feeling of not fitting in anywhere. (Award 1 mark for each side clearly stated, plus 1 mark if both sides are compared or contrasted.) Total: 3 marks.	3
8	Paragraph 4: tone is concerned / sombre — focuses on the negative consequences of "cultural dissonance" and feeling marginalised. Evidence: "persistent feeling of not quite fitting in anywhere." Paragraph 5: tone shifts to hopeful / empowering — reframes the multicultural experience as a strength. Evidence: "rare kind of empathy," "no small gift." Award 2 marks for each paragraph (1 mark: tone identified; 1 mark: supporting evidence). Total: 4 marks.	4
9	The writer means that growing up between cultures gives young people the ability to understand and relate to different perspectives — to "see the world through more than one lens." This is "rare" because most people only know one cultural viewpoint. Own evaluation of the argument should be supported with reasoning. Award 2 marks for the explanation, 2 marks for a reasoned personal evaluation. Total: 4 marks.	4

10	Extended response grid (10 marks): Content & argument [4]: Addresses the statement; uses passage evidence; adds own ideas/experience; clear position. Organisation [3]: Clear intro and conclusion; logical paragraphing; effective connectives. Language [3]: Accurate grammar and spelling; varied vocabulary; appropriate discursive register.	10
Section B — Language Use		
11	Its cultural heritage is celebrated every year by the community with a vibrant festival.	1
12	Local elders are teaching several traditional languages to young children.	1
13	The cultural practices of more than forty communities have been documented by researchers.	1
14	The President will open the new cultural centre next month.	1
15	Many minority languages and traditions are slowly being eroded by globalisation.	1
16	The student said (that) his/her grandmother had taught him/her everything he/she knew about their traditions.	1
17	The professor explained (that) cultural identity shapes / shaped how we see / saw ourselves and others.	1
18	The researcher asked the pupils if / whether they felt that their culture was properly represented in school.	1
19	The minister promised (that) they would introduce new guidelines to promote cultural inclusion in schools.	1
20	The elder advised the young people to learn to speak at least one of their heritage languages.	1
21	taught	1
22	would not have disappeared	1
23	preserve	1
24	had grown up	1
25	practised	1
26	in order to	1
27	on the other hand	1
28	Even though	1
29	as a result	1
30	Similarly	1
31	had learned / had learnt	1
32	has been held	1
33	are debating	1
34	had been writing	1
35	will announce	1

Section C — Writing (30 marks)		
C	Content & Task Fulfilment [12]: Task fully addressed; correct form; sufficient detail and development. Organisation & Structure [9]: Clear introduction and conclusion; logical paragraphing; effective connectives. Language & Style [9]: Accurate grammar, punctuation and spelling; varied sentences and vocabulary; appropriate register.	30
Section D — Vocabulary & Word Study		
36	Unable to satisfy or belong to either of two groups; in an awkward / uncertain position between two choices.	1
37	Made to feel comfortable, welcome, and at ease in a new place.	1
38	Become confused, disoriented, or uncertain about what is right or what they truly value in life.	1
39	Maintained her cultural traditions / kept them living and active in her daily life.	1
40	Communicates a great deal / expresses something very powerfully without many words.	1
Word forms	Row 1: diversity . Row 2: identify (verb). Row 3: integrated . Row 4: hand down / pass on / maintain (verb, accept any clear verb form). Row 5: representation .	5
41	A	1
42	D	1
43	E	1
44	C	1
45	B	1